

Hegel — Answer-Writing Toolkit

Seven verified PYQs and six original solved models

This is the topic's solved Mains/PYQ workbook and transfer manual. All 7 directly owned verified PYQs through 2026 receive complete independent model answers. These are independent learner practice, never an official UPSC key.

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What to recall and what to write

Demand	Recall first	Write for marks
Dialectical method	immanence; contradiction; determinate negation; mediation; sublation	demonstrate a transition; do not stop at T-A-S shorthand
Truth/Absolute	true as whole/result; concrete universal; substance-as-subject	show why process and result are inseparable
Phenomenal world	finite moment; nature as otherness; actuality	real but not self-sufficient; distinguish Kant and Berkeley
Kant challenge	negative noumenon; affection problem; limit	three prongs, Kant's reply, bounded ruling
History	consciousness of freedom; Objective Spirit; cunning of reason	mechanism plus stage scheme, example, Eurocentrism/teleology criticism
Recognition	struggle; fear; service; labour/Bildung	dependence reversal and bounded significance, not instant emancipation
System seam	Logic–Nature–Spirit; free release; impotence of nature	Schelling/Trendelenburg objection, Hegelian reply, residual limit

Must-write vocabulary

Method: immanent critique; abstract/negative/speculative moments; determinate negation; contradiction; mediation; negation of negation; *Aufhebung*; Being–Nothing–Becoming.

Metaphysics: concrete universal; identity-in-difference; bad and true infinite; Concept (*Begriff*); Absolute as result; Substance also Subject; Logic–Nature–Spirit; actuality (*Wirklichkeit*) versus mere existence (*Dasein*).

Phenomenology/history: recognition (*Anerkennung*); lord/bondsman; fear, service and labour (*Bildung*); Stoicism; Scepticism; Unhappy Consciousness; Objective Spirit; ethical life; consciousness of freedom; cunning of reason (*List der Vernunft*).

High-value analytical lines

- Dialectic is not applied to a finished object; it names the object's or concept's own failure to remain what it first claimed to be.
- Determinate negation constrains the successor, while sublation explains why development is cumulative rather than destructive.
- The Absolute is not an initial super-object but the result that includes the path of its own differentiation and return.
- Hegel pressures Kant most strongly where the noumenon is treated as a causally effective second world; a merely negative limiting concept is a stronger Kantian reply.
- Unequal recognition is conceptually unstable, but the lordship–bondage episode does not predict rapid historical emancipation.

- The Logic-to-Nature transition is coherent as a structural claim only if one grants the system's standpoint; Schelling's question about the sheer fact of existence remains.
- Hegelian history retains force as immanent criticism of institutions while losing authority as a Eurocentric universal teleology.

Introduction bank

1. "Hegel's dialectic is the immanent self-correction of finite determinations, and Absolute Idealism is the systematic result of that movement."
2. "Hegel radicalises Kant's constitutive turn by rejecting a permanently external thing-in-itself and treating thought and being as internally mediated."
3. "For Hegel the Absolute is not inert substance but subject: a whole that becomes itself through differentiation, negation and return."

Conclusion bank

- "The power of Hegel's position is its account of mediated intelligibility; its cost is the disputed necessity of the transitions that claim completeness."
- "Dialectic remains strongest as immanent criticism and weakest when retrospective intelligibility is promoted into universal necessity."
- "Hegel's Absolute preserves finite moments only if sublation genuinely retains difference rather than absorbing it."

Redrawable visuals and answer spines

IMMEDIACY -> INTERNAL FAILURE -> DETERMINATE NEGATION -> AUFHEBUNG
-> RICHER IMMEDIACY -> ... -> CONCRETE WHOLE

LOGIC: Idea in itself -> NATURE: Idea in otherness -> SPIRIT: Idea returned
SPIRIT: subjective -> objective -> absolute (art -> religion -> philosophy)

10 marks: precise thesis -> 3 moves -> example/text -> qualification -> verdict
15 marks: reconstruction -> system link -> objection/reply -> graded judgement
20 marks: full architecture -> two examples -> comparison -> strongest seam -> ruling

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline

Question wording and marks follow the repository-controlled Western Philosophy ledgers. For 2026, the portable exact-wording authority is [PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2026.md](#); the official scan/OCR is optional corroboration only. Hegel directly owns seven parts: 2019 Q1(c), 2020 Q1(d), 2021 Q2(a), 2022 Q3(b), 2023 Q1(b), 2025 Q1(e), and 2026 Q1(c). Years 2018 and 2024 have no direct Hegel-owned part. Model answers below are independent learner practice, not official UPSC answers.

Working answer bands: 10 marks about 150–200 words; 15 marks about 250–300 words; 20 marks about 340–400 words. Demand tables, marks notes and “why this earns marks” explanations sit outside the timed answer.

2019 · Q1(c) · 10 marks

Question: What is the role of dialectics in realizing the truth in Hegel’s philosophy?

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Source status	Exact wording and marks verified in the Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Explain the role of dialectic in truth, not merely define the method.
Non-negotiables	Define immanence; reconstruct determinate negation and sublation; use Being–Nothing–Becoming; connect process to “the True is the Whole”; qualify the T-A-S shorthand.
Ownership	Directly owned by Hegel; counted once

Independent model answer

For Hegel, dialectic is not a debating device imposed on material from outside. It is the immanent self-movement by which a finite determination exposes its own insufficiency and passes into a more adequate form. Its role is therefore constitutive of truth: truth is not an isolated proposition but “the True is the Whole,” the result together with the process of its development.

The movement has three moments. Understanding fixes an immediate category as self-sufficient. Determinate negation then reveals the category’s internal contradiction and yields a specific successor rather than empty nothing. Speculative reason sublates the earlier terms: it cancels their independence, preserves their partial truth, and raises them into a richer unity. In the Science of Logic, pure Being is indistinguishable from pure Nothing; their truth is Becoming.

Dialectic realises truth because each error is retained as a subordinate moment within a concrete universal, while no external criterion is imported. The familiar thesis-antithesis-synthesis formula is only later shorthand associated with Fichte and Chalybaeus; Hegel’s safer terms are moment, negation and sublation. Thus truth is achieved through mediated self-development, not given in an abstract beginning.

Qualification / criticism: The shorthand is later, and each transition still requires demonstration.

Why this earns marks: It defines dialectic as immanent self-movement, reconstructs determinate negation and sublation, and explains why developed totality rather than an isolated proposition is truth.

Exam-length guidance

150–200 words: 2-line thesis, 3 method moves, one worked example, one qualification, verdict.

2020 · Q1(d) · 10 marks

Question: Examine the reality of the phenomenal world in the light of Hegel's Absolute Idealism.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Source status	Exact wording and marks verified in the Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Examine whether and in what sense the phenomenal world is real within Absolute Idealism.
Non-negotiables	Reject both independent thing-in-itself and private illusion; explain finite mediated moment; distinguish Kant and Berkeley; give a graded verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned by Hegel; counted once

Independent model answer

Hegel's Absolute Idealism treats the phenomenal world as real, but not as self-subsistent or ultimate. It is neither Kant's appearance concealing an unknowable thing-in-itself nor Berkeley's collection of ideas perceived by finite spirits and continuously ordered by God. It is the finite self-manifestation of the Absolute.

The system presents the Idea in itself as Logic, the Idea outside itself as Nature, and the Idea returning to itself as Spirit. Nature and finite consciousness are therefore not illusions outside reality; they are necessary moments through which the rational whole differentiates and knows itself. Sublation does not destroy these moments. It cancels their claim to independence, preserves their determinate truth, and integrates them into Spirit's self-knowledge.

Hegel's distinction between mere existence, Dasein, and actuality, Wirklichkeit, supplies the qualification. A phenomenon can exist and exercise effects while imperfectly realising its concept. Its reality is consequently graded: finite things are genuine moments, yet they become intelligible only within the whole.

Thus the phenomenal world is real but not final. Hegel preserves empirical reality while rejecting both a permanently external noumenon and reduction to private ideas; appearance is the Absolute's mediated self-showing.

Why this earns marks: It preserves the phenomenal world's reality as a finite mediated moment, distinguishes Hegel from Berkeley and Kant, and gives a graded rather than eliminative verdict.

Exam-length guidance

150–200 words: 3-line doctrine, 5–6 lines on mediated reality, two contrasts, qualification and verdict.

2021 · Q2(a) · 20 marks

Question: Discuss Hegel's Dialectical method. Explain how his dialectical method leads him to the Absolute Idealism.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Source status	Exact wording and marks verified in the Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Discuss the full method and causally explain how that method yields Absolute Idealism.
Non-negotiables	Method with example; concrete universal; removal of external noumenal residue; substance-as-subject; Logic–Nature–Spirit; strongest transition objection and reply.
Ownership	Directly owned by Hegel; counted once

Independent model answer

Hegel's dialectical method is the immanent self-development of thought through contradiction, determinate negation and sublation. It is not an external technique applied to a passive subject matter. Followed systematically, it leads to Absolute Idealism because each allegedly self-sufficient determination proves relational, and the completed movement claims to leave no unintelligible remainder outside rational mediation.

The method has three moments. Understanding fixes an immediate category. Dialectical or negative reason exposes the contradiction generated by that category's own one-sidedness. Speculative reason then produces a determinate successor through *Aufhebung*, which cancels independence, preserves partial truth and raises both terms into a richer unity. The opening of the *Science of Logic* illustrates this movement: pure Being, because wholly indeterminate, is indistinguishable from pure Nothing; their truth is Becoming. The result is a concrete universal whose unity is articulated through difference. Thesis–antithesis–synthesis is only later shorthand associated with Fichte and Chalybaeus, not Hegel's regular formula.

This method leads toward Absolute Idealism in four steps. First, immanent criticism makes thought self-testing rather than dependent on an external standard. Second, Hegel challenges Kant's thing-in-itself: a determinately asserted limit is already thought relationally, while claims that a noumenal cause affects appearances use categories beyond their declared field. This pressures the idea of a permanently external unknowable remainder, though Kant's negative-noumenon reply remains available. Third, the Absolute is Subject, not merely Spinozist Substance: the whole differentiates itself and returns to self-knowledge. Fourth, the system maps this process as Idea in itself in Logic, Idea outside itself in Nature, and Idea returned to itself in Spirit, culminating conceptually in philosophy.

The exposed joint is the transition from Logic to Nature. Schelling objects that conceptual essence cannot generate the sheer fact that anything exists; Trendelenburg charges that movement is imported. Hegel's reply is that "free release" is logical, non-temporal and non-causal, and that nature's "impotence" allows contingency rather than deducing every fact. Even so, the passage is more coherent retrospectively than demonstratively necessary.

Qualification / criticism: The Logic-to-Nature transition remains the system's disputed joint.

Therefore dialectic yields Absolute Idealism as the claim that reality is an intelligible, self-developing whole knowing itself in Spirit. Its power lies in mediated totality; its residual weakness is the passage from logical necessity to existent Nature.

Why this earns marks: It integrates the method with Absolute Idealism through Kant, substance-as-subject and Logic-Nature-Spirit, then tests the system at its most difficult transition.

Exam-length guidance

340–400 words: about 40% method, 40% route to the Absolute, 20% criticism/reply and verdict.

2022 · Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: What is the dialectical method in the philosophy of Georg Wilhelm Hegel? How does this method help in realizing the Absolute? Discuss.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Source status	Exact wording and marks verified in the Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Define Hegel's method and show how it helps realise—not merely posit—the Absolute.
Non-negotiables	Immediacy, determinate negation, mediation and sublation; a worked triad; self-grounding thought; system map; qualified Logic-to-Nature seam.
Ownership	Directly owned by Hegel; counted once

Independent model answer

Hegel's dialectical method is the immanent development of a determination through its own contradiction. Understanding first fixes a category as immediate and self-sufficient. Dialectical reason exposes the category's one-sidedness through determinate negation, which yields a specific successor rather than empty cancellation. Speculative reason then sublates the opposed moments: *Aufhebung* cancels their independence, preserves their partial truth and raises them into a richer unity.

The opening of the *Science of Logic* is the model. Pure Being is so indeterminate that it cannot be distinguished from pure Nothing; their truth is Becoming. This is a logical transition, not a temporal sequence. It shows why truth is a concrete universal and why "the True is the Whole." The common thesis-antithesis-synthesis label is only shorthand associated with Fichte and Chalybaeus; Hegel's operative terms are moment, negation and sublation.

The method helps realise the Absolute because it removes supposedly external limits by showing their relational character. Hegel's challenge to Kant's thing-in-itself is that a determinately thought boundary is already mediated by thought; no positively characterised unknowable remainder can simply stand outside the process. The Absolute is therefore Subject, not merely Substance: it differentiates itself, becomes other, and returns to self-knowledge. Systematically, this is Idea in itself as Logic, Idea outside itself as Nature, and Idea returned to itself as Spirit, culminating in philosophical comprehension.

The difficult step is Logic's "free release" into Nature. Schelling argues that concepts cannot produce the fact of existence. Hegel can answer that the transition is logical rather than causal and that Nature includes contingency, but strict necessity remains disputed.

Qualification / criticism: The Logic-to-Nature transition remains demonstratively contested.

Thus dialectic realises the Absolute as rational self-comprehension, while the Logic-Nature seam limits the demonstration's force.

Why this earns marks: It uses Hegel's own vocabulary instead of a mechanical triad, shows how the Absolute is realised, and gives a qualified answer to the Logic-Nature objection.

Exam-length guidance

250–300 words: 1 paragraph method, 1 worked example, 1 paragraph route to Absolute, objection/reply, verdict.

2023 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: "History is a process of dialectical change." In the light of this statement discuss Hegel's approach in understanding history.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Source status	Exact wording and marks verified in the Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Apply dialectic to history: mechanism, direction, agency and critical evaluation.
Non-negotiables	Consciousness of freedom; one/some/all; contradiction within an embodied norm; cunning of reason; Objective Spirit; Eurocentrism and retrospective teleology.
Ownership	Directly owned by Hegel; counted once

Independent model answer

Hegel understands history as the dialectical development of Spirit through successive forms of freedom. His guiding claim is that world history is progress in the consciousness of freedom. The familiar sequence is: in the Oriental world one is free, in the Greek and Roman world some are free, and in the Germanic-Christian world all are free in principle.

The movement is dialectical because each historical order embodies a norm while restricting it. Athenian citizenship, for example, proclaims civic freedom yet rests on slavery. Such contradiction destabilises the existing form and enables a more adequate institutional order. Freedom becomes concrete in Objective Spirit through right, morality, family, civil society and the constitutional state.

Agency operates through the "cunning of reason." World-historical individuals pursue passions and limited aims, while their actions produce consequences that advance a wider rational development they did not design.

The account is powerful as immanent criticism: institutions can be judged by their own professed norms. However, its one-some-all scheme is Eurocentric, its necessity is reconstructed retrospectively, and Popper's historicism objection challenges its resistance to falsification. Hegel therefore illuminates history as conflict-driven institutional learning, but his claim of a necessary culmination should be treated cautiously.

Why this earns marks: It supplies mechanism, historical stages, institutional freedom, named examples and a critique of retrospective teleology rather than merely listing civilisations.

Exam-length guidance

150–200 words: thesis, compact stage line, mechanism and agency, one example, one criticism, verdict.

2025 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: How does Hegel challenge Kant’s distinction between Phenomena and Noumena? Discuss.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Source status	Exact wording and marks verified in the Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Reconstruct Hegel’s challenge to Kant fairly and adjudicate it.
Non-negotiables	State Kant’s negative noumenon; give Hegel’s three prongs; explain identity-in-difference; include Kant’s limiting-concept reply; bound the verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned by Hegel; counted once

Independent model answer

Kant distinguishes phenomena, objects appearing under our forms and categories, from unknowable noumena or things in themselves. Hegel challenges the permanence of this boundary.

First, a determinately stated limit is itself a thought: to identify what lies beyond thought already relates the two sides. Second, "thing-in-itself" is formed through concepts such as being, unity and causality, so it cannot be wholly external to conceptual determination. Third, if the noumenon is said to exist and affect sensibility, categories are being applied beyond the field in which Kant declares them valid. Hegel therefore treats subject and object as opposed moments to be mediated within the Absolute's self-knowledge, not as two permanently separated realms.

Kant may reply that the negative noumenon functions only as a limiting concept warning that appearances are not things as they are independently, rather than as a positively known object. Hegel's criticism is strongest against reified two-world and affection readings, and weaker against this modest limiting use.

Thus Hegel shows the instability of positively asserting an unknowable external remainder. Yet overcoming that boundary does not by itself prove every transition of Absolute Idealism; the critique establishes a problem more securely than it establishes Hegel's complete remedy.

Why this earns marks: It states Kant's position fairly, gives Hegel's three prongs, includes Kant's limiting-concept reply and reaches a bounded comparative verdict.

Exam-length guidance

150–200 words: 3 lines Kant, 6–7 lines Hegel, 3 lines reply and judgement.

2026 · Q1(c) · 10 marks

Question: Explain Hegel's idea that the concept of the Absolute as being is the concept of the Absolute as becoming as a process of self-development.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Source status	Exact wording and 10 marks verified in the repository-controlled 2026 Western Philosophy supplement; official-paper OCR is optional corroboration
Directive	Explain the identity of Absolute being with becoming; do not write a generic note on dialectic
Non-negotiables	Absolute as result and subject; Being–Nothing–Becoming; determinate negation; sublation; Logic–Nature–Spirit; qualification
Ownership	Directly owned by Hegel; counted once

Independent model answer

Hegel rejects the Absolute as a motionless being complete before the world. A static Absolute would exclude change and finite difference and therefore depend upon what it excludes. The Absolute is conceived as becoming: a self-developing whole whose being consists in differentiation and return.

The opening of the Science of Logic provides the model. Pure Being, because wholly indeterminate, cannot be distinguished from pure Nothing. Their truth is Becoming, the unity of coming-to-be and ceasing-to-be. This is not a temporal creation story. It exemplifies determinate negation: the insufficiency of one category yields a successor. Through *Aufhebung*, earlier terms are cancelled as independent, preserved as moments and raised into a richer determination.

The same structure defines the Absolute as result and as Subject, not merely Substance. The Idea articulates itself in Logic, externalises itself as Nature, and returns to self-knowledge as Spirit. Finite realities are therefore not outside the Absolute; they are moments through which it becomes explicit to

itself.

A qualification is necessary. Being-Nothing-Becoming illustrates self-development but does not prove every later transition, especially Logic's disputed passage to existent Nature. Hence Absolute being is becoming because its identity is identity-in-difference: it is what it becomes through self-differentiation, negation and return.

Why this structure earns marks

It answers the exact being/becoming relation, uses the canonical first transition, connects method to the whole system, and qualifies the move rather than merely repeating "everything changes."

Exam-length guidance

150–200 words: contrast static being with Hegel's result; give Being–Nothing–Becoming; define determinate negation and sublation; connect Logic–Nature–Spirit; end with the transition qualification.

Bounded cross-links — not Hegel-owned

Year/part	Primary owner	Hegel use only
2018 Q2(b)	Kant	Explain Hegel as culmination/overcoming only after "Understanding makes Nature" and Kantian limits are established.
2023 Q1(d)	Existentialism/Kierkegaard	Use system-versus-existing-individual as the Hegelian target; do not count it as Hegel's PYQ.
2024 Q2(a)	Empiricism/Berkeley	Contrast subjective idealism with Absolute Idealism after Berkeley is independently reconstructed.
2026 Q4(b)	Kant	Compare fixed conditions/phenomenal limit with dialectically developing categories and identity-in-difference; ownership remains Kant's.

Topic-specific self-evaluation rubric

Score each answer 0–2 on: exact directive; Hegelian vocabulary; demonstrated transition; worked example; system connection; source/provenance discipline; strongest objection and reply; bounded verdict. **14–16:** ready; **10–13:** repair mapped cells; **below 10:** reconstruct from the Revision Guide before rewriting.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Six original questions in the UPSC idiom — two at 10 marks, two at 15 and two at 20 — with complete model answers inside the declared bands. These are learner practice, not past papers.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain what Hegel means by sublation (*Aufhebung*) and state why the doctrine is indispensable to his history of philosophy. Discuss.

Independent model answer

The term. *Aufheben* carries three senses simultaneously, and Hegel exploits all three: to **cancel**, to **preserve** and to **raise up**. In a dialectical transition the claim to isolated sufficiency is cancelled, the valid determinate content is preserved, and that content is reorganised within a richer mediated unity.

Why all three are needed. Drop "cancel" and nothing has been criticised. Drop "raise" and two positions merely draw. Drop "preserve" and dialectic collapses into refutation-and-collapse — each stage discarded when its successor arrives.

The consequence for the history of philosophy. Because sublation preserves, an earlier system is **partial** rather than simply worthless. Hegel can therefore write the history of philosophy as a development in which each position contributes a determinate content that survives its own overthrow, rather than as a catalogue of errors. The same feature explains why truth for Hegel is a *result*: only a cumulative sequence can constitute a whole.

Verdict. ⚠️ The triple sense is genuinely load-bearing, but it does not license complacency: each transition must still be demonstrated, and not every error is automatically a preserved partial truth.

Why this earns marks

It defines all three operations of sublation, applies preservation to the history of philosophy, and qualifies the transition rather than treating partial truth as automatic.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish Hegel's true infinite from the bad infinite, and explain why the distinction is required by Absolute Idealism. Discuss.

Independent model answer

The bad infinite. A **spurious infinite** (*schlechte Unendlichkeit*) is one that stands *beyond* the finite in an endless "and so on". Its defect is structural: because it is defined by excluding the finite, the finite supplies its border, and whatever has a border is limited. An infinite reached by exclusion is therefore finite.

The true infinite. The genuine infinite **includes** finite self-limitation and return within itself. The finite is real *as a moment* — neither annihilated nor left standing outside as an independent remainder.

Why Absolute Idealism requires it. If the Absolute were one object over against finite objects, it would be exactly a bad infinite, and Hegel's whole position would collapse into the two-world picture he rejects in Kant. The distinction is what licenses the claim that the Absolute is not a thing behind the world but the world grasped as a self-developing whole, and it is also what secures the reality of appearance: a whole that annihilated its moments would have restored the exclusion it was meant to overcome.

Verdict. ⚠️ The distinction is the logical control behind the system; whether the finite retains genuine irreducibility inside it remains the standing objection.

Why this earns marks

It distinguishes the two infinities structurally, links the true infinite to mediated appearance and the Absolute, and states the unresolved objection about finite irreducibility.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "Hegel's dialectic is defensible as a description of conceptual breakdown and indefensible as a claim to necessity." Examine this statement.

Independent model answer

What the statement concedes. Taken as description, the dialectic is powerful and unusually economical. It requires no external criterion: a determination is tested only by the claim it makes for itself, and its failure is generated internally. Determinate negation then fixes the successor, so the sequence is not arbitrary, and sublation preserves what was valid, so the movement is cumulative. Applied to the opening of the *Science of Logic*, the account can be checked with nothing assumed: pure being, having no determination, is indistinguishable from pure nothing, and becoming is the truth of their inseparability.

What the statement denies. The claim to *necessity* is a different matter. **Trendelenburg** argues in the *Logische Untersuchungen* (1840) that transition presupposes movement, becoming and time, whereas the categories are static determinations, so Hegel must borrow from intuition the very thing he claims to derive. Hegel's reply is that conceptual instability is not borrowed motion — the "movement" is the self-undermining of a determination that cannot be thought consistently. ⚠️ The reply is available, but it has never been made uncontroversially, and it does not show that the successor is the *only* possible one.

The concession Hegel himself makes. The necessity is visible only retrospectively — "the owl of Minerva spreads its wings only with the falling of the dusk". That protects him from the charge of false prophecy at the cost of conceding what the statement asserts.

Verdict. ⚠️ Accurate, with one refinement. The dialectic is defensible exactly to the extent that it is descriptive of conceptual breakdown, and indefensible to the extent that it claims *predictive* force; between those poles lies a genuine third possibility — retrospective intelligibility — which is weaker than necessity and stronger than mere description.

Why this earns marks

It separates description, necessity and retrospective intelligibility, stages Trendelenburg's objection and Hegel's reply, and gives a graded verdict rather than a binary dismissal.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Assess the view that Hegel's identification of the rational with the actual makes his philosophy a defence of the existing order.

Independent model answer

The charge. The Preface to the *Philosophy of Right* declares that "what is rational is actual, and what is actual is rational". Read straightforwardly, this appears to certify whatever exists — and Hegel's own accommodation with the Prussian state has long been cited as evidence that he meant it that way.

The technical reply. The sentence turns on **actuality (*Wirklichkeit*)**, the effective unity of essence and existence — the realised operation of a concept — and not on bare **determinate existence (*Dasein*)**. An institution can perfectly well *exist* without being *actual*, if it fails to realise the concept it claims to embody. Far from blocking criticism, the distinction supplies its standard: a defective institution is measured against the concept it does not realise. ⚠️ *wirklich* must be translated or glossed, since rendering it "existing" makes the sentence assert the opposite of Hegel's intention.

What the reply does not settle. ⚠️ Two residues remain. First, the criterion is only as good as its application, and critics can reasonably ask whether Hegel applied it too gently to the modern constitutional state. Second, the same conservatism charge attaches to his philosophy of history, where a retrospective teleology can rationalise victors and understate contingency, colonialism, class and gender exclusion. The actuality/existence distinction is a defence of the *formula*; it is not a defence of every use Hegel made of it.

Verdict. ⚠️ The view is mistaken as a reading of the doctrine and not baseless as a reading of the man. The formula licenses immanent criticism; Hegel's own political conclusions remain contestable, and the honest answer says both in the same paragraph.

Why this earns marks

It controls the *Wirklichkeit/Dasein* distinction, uses it as a standard of immanent criticism, and concedes the separate political and historical residue.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "The transition from the Logic to the Philosophy of Nature is the point at which Hegel's system either completes itself or shows its seam." Critically examine.

Independent model answer

The problem, stated exactly. The *Science of Logic* claims to move by strict internal necessity from Being to the Absolute Idea, with nothing brought in from outside. The *Encyclopaedia* then passes from Logic to the Philosophy of Nature — from a self-contained order of pure categories to space, time, matter and brute givenness. If the step is necessary, how can a category *produce* an existent? If it is not, presuppositionless self-grounding collapses at the moment of completion.

Hegel's text. At §244 the Absolute Idea "freely releases itself" (*entläßt sich frei*) and lets the moment of its particularity go forth as Nature; §247 defines Nature as "the Idea in the form of otherness". ⚠️ Renderings differ, so the § should be given and the phrase marked as a rendering.

The defensible reading. The release is neither temporal nor causal: there is no "before" in which Logic existed alone, and categories exert no force. It is **logical and structural** — the Absolute Idea is pure self-relating form, and a form that is nothing but self-relation has no content of its own, so it *is* its own externality. ✅ §250 confirms this by conceding the "impotence of nature" (*die Ohnmacht der Natur*): nature cannot hold fast to the Concept, which is why it teems with contingency. Hegel therefore does **not** deduce particular natural facts, and the charge that he "deduced the planets" attacks a caricature.

The objections. Feuerbach (1839) calls the passage creation *ex nihilo* with the Creator renamed; Hegel can invert the parallel, holding that Christian *Vorstellung* pictures narratively what the *Logic* states conceptually — a reply that works only for those who grant that philosophy translates religion without loss. **Analytic critics** object that "resolves" and "releases" are verbs of agency applied to a concept; the reply that Hegel's German uses reflexive constructions is correct, but the metaphor cannot be fully cashed out. **Schelling**, in the Berlin lectures of 1841–2 delivered to an audience including Kierkegaard and Engels, presses the decisive charge: a rational system is "negative philosophy" only — it shows what anything must be *if* it is, never *that* anything is.

Verdict. ⚠️ The statement is accurate. Read as structure the transition is coherent; read as demonstration it is not, since the necessity is intelligible only retrospectively, from within Nature. Schelling's objection therefore lands, and the post-Hegelian century divides accordingly: Marx keeps the dialectic and drops the Idea, Kierkegaard and Heidegger keep existence and drop the system.

Why this earns marks

It states the category-to-existence problem, anchors all three sections, evaluates Feuerbach, analytic and Schelling objections, and ends with a qualified systemic verdict.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Examine how far Hegel's phenomenological analyses of lordship–bondage and the unhappy consciousness demonstrate the dialectical method rather than merely illustrating it.

Independent model answer

The question's force. A demonstration establishes that the transition had to occur; an illustration only shows what a transition looks like. Hegel's claim is the stronger one — that in the *Phenomenology* the philosopher merely watches while a shape of consciousness destroys itself by its own criterion — so the two episodes are a fair test.

Lordship and bondage (Ch. IV A). Two self-consciousnesses seek recognition and enter a life-and-death struggle; asymmetric roles emerge, as a **result**, when one submits rather than sustain the risk of death. The reversal is then internally generated. Recognition is worth having only from a consciousness acknowledged as free, so reducing the other to dependence destroys the value being sought; and the lord, no longer engaging the world directly, becomes dependent on the bondsman's work. On the other side, **fear** dissolves everything the bondsman took as fixed, **service** disciplines desire, and **formative labour** leaves a persisting form in the object through which he meets his own agency and is himself formed (*Bildung*). ✅ Nothing external intervenes; the lord gets exactly what he demanded.

The unhappy consciousness (Ch. IV B). Freedom is next sought in thought. Stoicism claims freedom "on the throne or in chains" and, being indifferent to all content, can answer only "the true, the good" in general. Scepticism enacts the negativity Stoicism implied and falls into performative self-contradiction — asserting that nothing can be asserted while continuing to live as a determinate individual. That contradiction, becoming conscious of itself, *is* the unhappy consciousness, divided between the Unchangeable and the Changeable. Through devotion (*Andacht*), alienated work and total externalisation (*Entäußerung*) to a mediator, it reaches the reversal: complete renunciation removes the particular self that stood opposed to the universal, so the renunciation **is** the achievement.

How far the claim holds. ⚠️ The internal generation is genuine, and the analytic charge that this is literary description underestimates the performative contradiction in Scepticism. But the necessity is retrospective in both cases, and neither episode shows that its successor was the *only* available one.

Verdict. ⚠️ They demonstrate more than illustration and less than necessity. That Feuerbach and Marx took the diagnosis while dropping the resolution, and Kierkegaard took the diagnosis while denying any resolution, is the best evidence both that Hegel identified something real and that he resolved it too quickly.

Why this earns marks

It reconstructs both episodes by their internal criteria, distinguishes demonstration from illustration and necessity, and uses later receptions only to support a bounded verdict.